



HE CAME IN AS AN OUTSIDER BUT HOODA (CENTRE) HAS REACHED OUT TO THE STATE'S VOTERS

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claims there is a strong undercurrent against the Congress which is not borne out by the Lok Sabha elections which saw the Congress winning nine of the 10 seats. The present Congress Government rode to power on its anti-corruption slogan. Memories may have begun to fade, but five years ago a major flutter was caused by the Congress's chargesheet that listed lucid details with panoramic pictures of the wealth worth thousands of crores that the Chautalas had allegedly amassed in India and abroad, while in power. What the public apparently refuses to forget and forgive the Chautalas is for their domineering demeanour of doing things. Many see them as despots, as overlords who deserve their current predicament of powerlessness.

On the other hand, Bhu-pinder Hooda, who was an unlikely candidate for the chief minister's chair even after the party had swept the Assembly polls, has

emerged stronger by the day. The Jat leader has been able to woo a considerably large chunk from his community which used to be a tried and trusted votebank of the Chautala family. Hooda has thus inflicted a severe blow on the INLD.

While having a Jat leader at the helm of affairs proved to be just the right strategy for the party, Hooda was quick to pick up tips from Chautala's mistakes and misdeeds. He consciously worked on his public dealing and today the public carries a much better, cleaner impression of him. His relatively non-controversial image has been supplemented by the efforts of his son, Deepinder Singh, the Congress MP from Rohtak. This and the weak opposition were the major reasons why he swept the Lok Sabha polls. Riding high on confidence, Hooda chose to go in for polls about seven months ahead of

HARYANA		Total Strength 90	
PARTIES		SEATS 2005	Vote Share %
 Indian National Congress		67	42.5
 Bharatiya Janata Party		2	10.4
 Indian National Lok Dal		9	26.8
Independents and others		12	20.3

In the 2005 elections, INLD and BJP were allies

schedule. With the Opposition in total disarray, and all the possible permutations and combinations yielding nothing, the Congress looks like it is on a stronger wicket than it has ever been before. It doesn't need rocket science to say that the Chautalas are down. Yet, given the glory of their heydays in Haryana, it would be foolish to count them out. ■